1.5 His First Flight

Warming up!

Chit-Chat

1. Form Groups of 5. Remember your past days and share with your friends about memories of your first day at school or your first attempt at cooking.

   What role did your parents, siblings play to help to overcome your fear?

1. Discuss and answer.

1. Are there any situations when you get afraid?	.....
2. How would you react if you had to travel alone?	.....
3. How would you react if you had to stay alone at home?	.....
4. What would you do if you were lost in a new city?	.....

2. Complete the following table.

Idioms	Meanings	Your own sentences
1. bird's eye view	view from somewhere high	
2. as free as a bird	If he/she is carefree	After finishing her exam. she will be as free as a bird.
3. eagle's eye	His ability to observe something closely	
4. spread ones wings	to try to work on things independently	

Find more such idioms using the following key words.

fly name of animals colours

His First Flight

The young seagull was alone on his **ledge**. His two brothers and his sister had already flown away the day before. He had been afraid to fly with them. Somehow when he had taken a little run forward to the **brink** of the ledge and attempted to flap his wings he became afraid. The great expanse of sea stretched down beneath, and it was such a long way down – miles down. He felt certain that his wings would never support him; so he bent his head and ran away back to the little hole under the ledge where he slept at night. Even when each of his brothers and his little sister, whose wings were far shorter than his own, ran to the brink, flapped their wings, and flew away, he failed **to muster up courage** to take that plunge which appeared to him so desperate. His father and mother had come around calling to him **shrilly**, **upbraiding** him, threatening to let him starve on his ledge unless he flew away. But for the life of him he could not move.

That was twenty-four hours ago. Since then nobody had come near him. The day before, all day long, he had watched his parents flying about with his brothers and sister, perfecting them in the art of flight, teaching them how to **skim** the waves and how to dive for fish. He had, in fact, seen his older brother catch his first **herring** and **devour** it, standing on a rock, while his parents circled around raising a proud **cackle**. And all the morning the whole family had walked about on the big plateau midway down the opposite **cliff** taunting him for his **cowardice**.

The sun was now ascending the sky, blazing on his ledge that faced the south. He felt the heat because he had not eaten since the previous nightfall.

He stepped slowly out to the brink of the ledge, and standing on one leg with the other leg hidden under his wing, he closed one eye, then the other, and pretended to be falling asleep. Still they took no

- **ledge :** a narrow horizontal shelf projecting from a wall or (here) a cliff
- **brink :** the edge of a steep place

✦ What did the young seagull feel?

Guess the meaning of :

- muster up courage
- ascending the sky

- **shrilly :** in a loud, harsh voice
- **upbraiding :** scolding
- **skim :** move lightly just above a surface (here, the sea)
- **herring :** a soft-finned sea fish
- **devour :** eat up hungrily
- **cackle :** utter a shrill cry
- **cliff :** a high steep face of a rock
- **cowardice :** lack of courage to face danger

✦ Why did the young seagull feel hot?

notice of him. He saw his two brothers and his sister lying on the plateau dozing with their heads sunk into their necks. His father was **preening** the feathers on his white back. Only his mother was looking at him. She was standing on a little high **hump** on the plateau, her white breast thrust forward. Now and again, she tore at a piece of fish that lay at her feet and then **scrapped** each side of her beak on the rock. The sight of the food maddened him. How he loved to tear food that way, scrapping his beak now and again to **whet** it.

"Ga, ga, ga", he cried begging her to bring him some food. "Gaw-col-ah", she screamed back **derisively**. But he kept calling **plaintively**, and after a minute or so he uttered a joyful scream. His mother had picked up a piece of the fish and was flying across to him with it. He leaned out eagerly, tapping the rock with his feet, trying to get nearer to her as she flew across. But when she was just opposite to him, she halted, her wings motionless, the piece of fish in her beak almost within reach of his beak. He waited a moment in surprise, wondering why she did not come nearer, and then, maddened by hunger, he dived at the fish. With a loud scream he fell outwards and downwards into space. Then a **monstrous** terror seized him and his heart stood still. He could hear nothing. But it only lasted a minute. The next moment he felt his wings spread outwards. The wind rushed against his breast feathers, then under his stomach, and against his wings. He could feel the tips of his wings cutting through the air. He was not falling headlong now. He was **soaring** gradually downwards and outwards. He was no longer afraid. He just felt a bit **dizzy**. Then he flapped his wings once and he soared upwards. "Ga, ga, ga, Ga, ga ga, Gaw-col-ah," his mother swooped past him, her wings making a loud noise. He answered her with another scream. Then his father flew over him screaming. He saw his two brothers and his sister flying around him **curveting** and **banking** and soaring and diving.

✦ What were the young seagull's parents doing?

- **preening :** making an effort to clean feathers with the beak
- **hump :** a round raised mass on land
- **scrapped :** rubbed
- **whet :** sharpen
- **derisively :** in a manner showing someone that she/he is stupid
- **plaintively :** expressing sorrow

Guess the meaning of :

- soar
- maddened by hunger
- seized
- **monstrous :** shocking
- **dizzy :** having an uncomfortable feeling of spinning around and losing one's balance
- **curveting :** leaping like a horse
- **banking :** flying with one wing higher than the other

✦ What were the young seagull's brothers and sister doing?



Then he completely forgot that he had not always been able to fly, and commended himself to dive and soar and curve, **shrieking** shrilly.

He was near the sea now, flying straight over it, facing straight out over the ocean. He saw a vast green sea beneath him, with little **ridges** moving over it and he turned his beak sideways and cawed **amusedly**.

His parents and his brothers and sister had landed on this green flooring ahead of him. They were **beckoning** to him, calling shrilly. He dropped his legs to stand on the green sea. His legs sank into it. He screamed with fright and attempted to rise again flapping his wings. But he was tired and weak with hunger and he could not rise, **exhausted** by the strange exercise. His feet sank into the green sea, and then his belly touched it and he sank no farther. He was floating on it, and around him his family was screaming, praising him and their beaks were offering him scraps of dog-fish.

He had made his first flight.

- Liam O' Flaherty

✦ What did he forget?

- **shrieking :** making a loud cry
- **ridge :** a chain of hills
- **amusedly :** pleasurably
- **beckon :** to give a signal to move near or to follow
- **exhaust :** wear out

ENGLISH WORKSHOP

1. State whether the following statements are true or false.

(a) The young seagull was not confident about the ability of his wings.

(b) The young seagull's parents guided and improved his siblings in the art of flying.

(c) When the young seagull pretended to be falling asleep, his parents noticed him.

(d) Flying across the young seagull, the mother dropped a piece of fish into his beak.

2. Complete the following statements.

(a) The seagull is afraid to fly because .....

.....

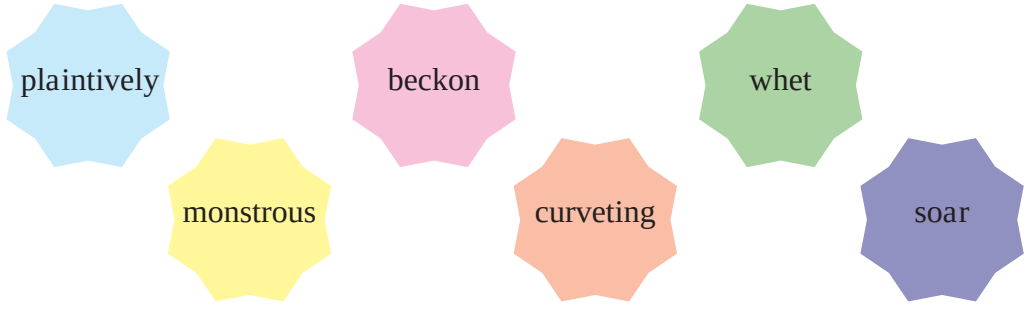
(b) Young birds are afraid to make their first flight because .....

.....

(c) Human beings find it difficult to face great challenges because .....

.....

3. Read the following words carefully and make meaningful sentences of your own, and write in your notebook.



4. Read the following words carefully and fill in the blanks by choosing appropriate word given in brackets.

(afraid, plunged, appeared, shrilly, skimmed, devoured, cowardice)

(a) Arun is full of .....

(b) The violin played very ..... and merrily.

(c) Ravi said, "Are you really..... of the dark?"

(d) The whole village ..... into darkness.

(e) The lions ..... their prey, hungrily.

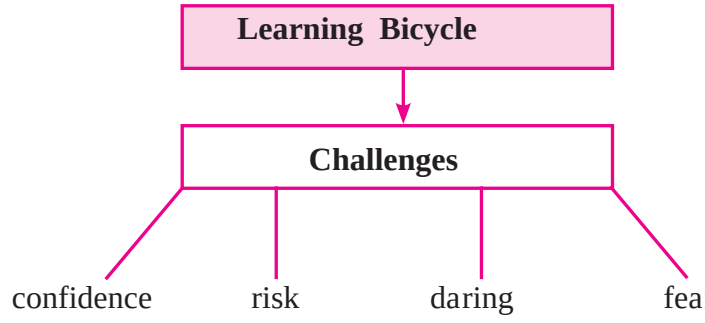
(f) He ..... through the report.

(g) One by one, the stars ..... in the sky.

5. Read about the space mission of Sunita Williams. Imagine you are going to interview her. Frame 10 to 12 interview relevant questions regarding –

1. her early life, training
2. education
3. her actual flight into space
4. future plans
5. her message to viewers.

6. Describe in your notebook the challenges you faced while learning to ride a bicycle/swimming or any skill. Take hints from the web to complete your write-up.



7. Project :

(a) Collect the career options related with flying. Find out the institutes where training of your options is given.
Find out the detailed information about the fees, duration of training and future prospects of it.

(b) Collect or draw different pictures of birds from your surroundings and write about them. Make a chart with some information about each.

Language Study

1. There are words that have the same pronunciation but differ in spellings. They are called **Homophones.** For example, (a) fair-fare (b) know-no

Sometimes the words have the same spellings and pronunciation but can have different meanings in different situations.

They are called **Homographs**. For example, (a) **watch**-observe **watch**-shows time

(b) **fair**- not very good, not very bad

fair- an exhibition and sale of items

fair- of complexion, skin tone

Note : Homophones and Homographs are together known as **Homonyms.**

Give the Homophones of the following.

(a) blue ..... (b) bear ..... (c) beet ..... (d) to ..... (e) son .....

2. Find from the lesson the Homophones of the following.

(A) Pick the Homophones from the text.

1. see -
2. wood -
3. there -
4. scene -
5. won -
6. eye -
7. peace -
8. threw -
9. hence -
10. knot -

(B) Explain how the underlined Homographs differ in meaning.

1. (a) He <u>saw</u> his two brothers. .....

   (b) The woodcutter cut the weaked branch with his sharp <u>saw</u> .....

2. (a) The bird injured his <u>wings</u>. .....

   (b) He lives in the 'c' <u>wing</u> of the building. .....

3. (a) The aeroplane will <u>land</u> at 9.00 pm. sharp. .....

   (b) He owns 10 acre of <u>land</u>. .....

4. (a) The <u>head</u> of the institution was on leave. .....

   (b) He bend his <u>head</u> down with chin. .....

3. Read the following sentences carefully, underline the verbs and find out the tenses in the sentences.

(a) The sun was now ascending the sky.

(b) Still they took no notice of him.

(c) She is standing on a little high hump on the plateau.

(d) He leaned out eagerly.

(e) He just felt dizzy.

Adverb

An adverb is a word that tells us something more about a Verb, an Adjective, or another Adverb.

About a Verb : He runs **fast**.

The girls sang **sweetly**.

Suddenly the baby started crying.

About an Adjective : This chain is **very** sturdy.

The tea is **too** hot.

About another Adverb : You should run **very** fast.

About a Phrase or Sentence : Unfortunately, your answer is incorrect.

Adverbs give us information about :

Place, for example, Go **there**, come **in**.

Time, for example, I will do my homework **tomorrow**.

I need a pencil **now**.

Manner or the way something is done, for example,

Read **slowly**, write **well**

Degree, for example, the water is **too** cold.

Many adverbs end with –ly, such as 'slowly' actually, surprisingly etc. Like adjectives, adverbs can also be used in comparative and superlative degree forms. Examples :

- He spoke most impressively.
- They danced **more** gracefully.

- **Passive :**

Many actions involve two people/things – one that performs the action and one that is affected by the action.

Example : *Sonali ate the mango.*

Here, the action of eating involves Sonali (who eats) and the mango (which gets eaten). Sonali is the subject and 'mango' is the object of the verb 'eat'. When you want to talk about **who performed** the action, the **doer** of the action is the **subject**.

Sometimes, you want focus on the object – the thing affected by the action. Then you make it the subject of that sentence.

Example : *The mango* was eaten.

You **may or may not mention the doer** – here, Sonali or the person who ate it. This is **passive construction** or **passive voice**. In this type of construction, the thing affected by the verb is the **subject** of the sentence, the verb is in the **passive form (be + past participle),** and the **'doer'** of the action **may or may not be mentioned.**

In the following examples of passive voice, the 'doer' of action is not mentioned.

Examples : • The plants are **pruned**.

- A cup of tea **is offered** to any guest ...
- Many anecdotes, related to Mark Twain, **are told** ...

If we wish to mention the 'doer' in passive sentences, we mention it by adding 'by' before it.

Example : This pen *was given* to me *by* my Aunt.

Note that only transitive verbs can be used in the passive voice.